



Budget Battle

Independent Living Game • profiles, choices, surprise cards & score sheet

FOR STAFF • 30-MINUTE SESSION

Purpose: Practice tradeoffs using realistic monthly income and expenses.

Materials: Print profile, choice menu, budget sheet, surprise cards; calculator optional.

Easy flow: 5 min choose profile • 15 min build budget • 5 min surprise card • 5 min defend choices.

Choose Your Adult-Life Profile

A • First Apartment

Take-home income: \$1,850/month

Goal: live independently and still save \$100.

B • Working & Saving

Take-home income: \$2,150/month

Goal: save \$300/month for a car.

C • New Job, Tight Budget

Take-home income: \$1,600/month

Goal: avoid using credit for regular expenses.

Expense Choice Menu

Housing

- ☐ Roommate apartment \$650/month
- ☐ Small apartment alone \$925/month
- ☐ Stay with family/contribute \$350/month

Transportation

- ☐ Used car costs \$420/month
- ☐ Ride-share/bus mix \$220/month
- ☐ Family ride + gas help \$140/month

Phone

- ☐ Basic plan \$45/month
- ☐ Unlimited plan \$85/month
- ☐ Premium plan + device \$135/month

Food

- ☐ Mostly cook at home \$275/month
- ☐ Cook + some takeout \$400/month
- ☐ Frequent takeout \$575/month

Fun/Subscriptions

- ☐ Low-cost \$35/month
- ☐ Moderate \$90/month
- ☐ High \$180/month

My Monthly Budget

Category	My Choice	Amount
Income		
Housing		
Transportation		
Phone		
Food		
Fun/Subscriptions		
Savings Goal		
Other		
TOTAL EXPENSES		
MONEY LEFT		
Over/Under Budget		

Rule

You must choose ONE option from every category. If you go over budget, revise your choices. If you have money left, decide whether to save it, spend it, or split it.

Surprise Cards • Cut Apart

FLAT TIRE Pay \$180 this month.	EXTRA SHIFT Add \$120 take-home income.
BIRTHDAY INVITE Decide: spend \$60, choose a \$20 option, or decline.	PHONE SCREEN CRACKED Repair now for \$110 or wait and protect the phone.
GROCERY PRICE JUMP Add \$35 to food this month.	REFUND You receive an unexpected \$75 refund.
RIDE CANCELLED Spend \$28 on an emergency ride to work or find another safe plan.	SUBSCRIPTION RENEWAL A forgotten \$19.99 subscription renews.

Wrap-Up • Get Them Talking

- 💬 Which expense was hardest to cut?

- 💬 What choice gave you the most freedom later in the month?

- 💬 What would you change if your income dropped by \$200?
